

Despite its prime location in Dhaula Kuan, rich legacy and a large student body, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma (ARSD) College was rarely the first choice for top-scoring students coming to Delhi University (DU). That changed with National Institutional Ranking Framework or NIRF 2024 where ARSD emerged in 5th place. "This isn't just improvement, it's a leap," says ARSD principal Prof. Gyantosh Kumar Jha, sitting in his office surrounded by student souvenirs. "Overtaking SRCC, Lady Shri Ram, even St Stephen's—DU's hallmark colleges—is a reversal no one saw coming, though the pieces had been carefully laid out for years. Not just academics, focus on all-round development of students, that's the soul of what we tried to do here."

It shows. It has been a quiet journey of evolution, pouring crores into infrastructure, overhauling the curriculum, cultivating a dynamic research culture and placing faith in its students to deliver the results. Today, ARSD proudly boasts the highest NAAC (National Assessment and Accreditation Council) score among DU colleges: an A++ with a CGPA of 3.77. In 2023, it was declared the best DU college under the NIRF's special category, 'Research and Professional Practice', awarded an outstanding 94.84 out of 100. The college has published more than 1,000 research papers, secured many patents and numerous government research projects. What distinguishes ARSD, though, is its pioneering move to get undergraduates, and not just postgraduates, to collaborate with the faculty on year-round research. "Our students' research papers are regularly published in international journals," says Prof. Jha. "We encourage students to question, explore, build ideas, be it in the arts, sciences, or social sciences."

Fortunately, ARSD's quest for academic excellence has not come at the cost of its culturally vibrant atmosphere. Its 40-day theatre workshop every year has become a signature initiative, attended every year by alumni as well as theatre enthusiasts at home and abroad. "It's a big deal here," the principal says. "Our students got selected for the National School of Drama. This workshop is a way for them to gear up for it."

GURUSPEAK



"When they (students) leave this college, we want them to not only excel in academics, but also become ideal human beings in society"

PROF. GYANTOSH KUMAR JHA, *Principal, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma College*

STUDENTSPAKE



"At ARSD, professors don't just simply pass on knowledge to students. We hold philosophical discussions, carry out group research and go on field trips. No other college does field trips for its literature students as much as ARSD does"

PRITHVIRAJ PATRA
BA (Hons) English, 3rd year

A MODERN CAMPUS

Walking around the campus today, you encounter a space redesigned for contemporary times. Classrooms are now digitally equipped, labs have been spruced up and sustainability is a visible commitment, reflected in the bamboo structures, the manicured lawns, rainwater harvesting systems and vermicomposting units. Administrative processes are digitised, CCTV cameras ensure safety and the newly renovated canteen serves delicious meals with a side dish of nostalgia.

Most crucially, a new kind of student is now filing past ARSD's gates—those with marks in the 90s and seeking a mix of a rigorous academic environment and creative freedom. Placement offers have surged, tie-ups with prestigious institutions like the National Productivity Council and the Netaji Subhas University of Technology have deepened and the faculty is encouraged to invest in personal growth—collectively logging in 1,100 hours of professional development in the past five years.

This transformation hasn't happened overnight, nor is it a result of any single sweeping reform. It's the product of a steady, determined pursuit of excellence. "We were never tied to rankings," says Jha. "We were chasing quality. The rankings followed." ■

*College showing highest improvement in scores in past five years